

In the Internet rainforest, search the Amazon

Friend, or foe? It would seem 'friend', but that's what they said about the British East India Company! Amazon's latest search service A9 incorporates search results from Google, and allows users to search Amazon's digital database of published book content.

It works with a simple premise, but as a technology, it is highly complex, with millions of algorithms running in the background.

Amazon's business unit—A9.com Inc of Palo Alto, California—built the service that remembers users' searches, and offers a toolbar that allows them to make and save notes on a Web page—much like a reader might scribble in the margins of a book.

The service, located at www.a9.com, also incorporates lucrative paid-search advertisements from Google, which has been providing search and advertising services to Amazon for a little over a year.

Web search is already a cut-throat Internet business, with dominant players such as Google and Yahoo! now being challenged by Microsoft. With Amazon, we believe, the slice just got a little thinner.

snapshot

For every **US\$1** spent on offshore jobs, the **US economy** gets back **\$1.12**

Source: www.theregister.co.uk

And now, bits on paper

So the paperless office is a myth, after all. Sony Corp, the world's leading electronics firm, and Toppan Printing Co of Japan, have developed a new optical disc made mostly out of—hold your collective breaths—paper!

In fact, the two companies

times more information than current discs, thanks to blue-laser DVD—a technology expected to replace current red-laser DVD players soon.

The paper disc is based on a technology called Blu-Ray, and is supported by a consortium of electronics makers, including Sony, Matsushita Elec-



even claim that the disc will be compatible with next-generation DVD players, and is capable of storing up to five

tric, and the Dutch firm, Philips.

In which case, will copying on discs now be called paper recycling?

It's radio and it's visual

Trust Nokia to stretch the boundaries of imagination. The Finnish telecom giant has tied up with HP, along with who they plan to launch a Visual Radio service later this year.

Nokia will supply the content, while HP will provide computing equipment to store the artist and title information as well as promotional information. The service may be subscription based.

Users of the service will be

able to view artists, songs, and concerts. Nokia plans to sell both high and low end phones that will connect to the Visual Radio service, and perhaps, at a later date, make available the service to other handset makers.

Well this reminds us of the time when people asked those with mobile phones for cricket scores thinking they have a radio they are hearing near their ears. That age has just come full circle.

RFID is coming

Before you read the piece on Radio Frequency Identification (see *Beyond Barcodes*, Page 124), here is something to start you off.

Retail giant Wal-Mart, and the US Defense Department have mandated the usage of RFID from their suppliers. Incidentally, a recent Forrester Research showed study

showed that RFID suppliers may not be able to meet the January 2005 mandate; Wal-Mart though, refutes the study. Analysts talk of lack of clarity at implementation levels, but many feel that there are going to be rigorous implementation trials over the span of this year. We are waiting for it to happen here, too!



Spam

Beware, Spammer—the Law's here!

Howard Carmack of Buffalo, New York, also known as the 'Buffalo Spammer', became the first spammer ever to be tried in court. He's been convicted on charges of identity theft and falsifying business records, according to the New York State Attorney General. He sent more than 800 million messages using Earthlink accounts.

EarthLink accused Carmack of using e-mail accounts belonging to other people, to send out floods of spam that advertised get-rich-quick schemes, herbal stimulants and cable TV descramblers.

Carmack will appear in court on May 27, and faces three to seven years in prison.

Could this precedent act as a deterrent to spammers world-wide?

XXX to be brown-paper-bagged

If the US Federal Trade Commission has its way, you won't be embarrassed the next time you open a mail inviting you to visit a porn site. Starting May 19th, sexually explicit e-mail will have to bear a label reading "Sexually-Explicit:", and the messages themselves cannot contain graphic material.

This step is sure to reduce cases of total embarrassment, such as happen when you inadvertently open porn spam just when your boss is behind you.

snapshot

Germans send **200 million** sms and e-mail messages a day

Source: www.theregister.co.uk